

Talent management

The Indian Railways, recognizing the importance of developing sports talent in their ranks, has taken an active interest in building a strong sports cadre. It offers innumerable opportunities to sportspersons interested in participating in national championships, including civilian awardees who have been honoured with the Padma Shri, Arjuna, Dhyan Chand, Dronacharya, and the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna awards.

It also ensures steady employment, training, and coaching facilities. Its goal to build a sports cadre has meant that the Indian Railways has instituted recruitment policies especially for sporting talent, as well as several measures such as special casual leave to ensure uninterrupted training throughout the year, and out-of-turn promotions and incentives for high-performing athletes. The railway calendar now recognizes 28 sport disciplines.

Making a name

After the success at the 1948 London Olympics, India went on to win many more medals internationally with the men and women from the railways playing a significant role. In fact, the 81-member Indian contingent at the 2012 London Olympics had 12 railway sportspersons, while the 2016 Rio Olympics had 35 out of the 121-member contingent.

Hockey has always seen a good representation of railwaymen, and more recently women. Leslie Claudius, Mohinder Lal, and Harbinder Singh were all part of teams that won Olympic medals, including the gold on three occasions.

Boxer Vijender Singh and wrestler Sushil Kumar, both Olympic medallists, began their careers with the Indian Railways. Incidentally, Kumar is the only Indian double medallist at the Olympics from the railways – winning the bronze at the 2008 Beijing Olympics and silver at the 2012 London Olympics in freestyle wrestling.

Cricket, of course, is never far behind. The railways have produced cricketing giants who went on to become a steady part of the sport. Among the most successful are former Indian captain, Mahendra Singh Dhoni, who worked as a Travelling Ticket Examiner (TTE) with the South Eastern Railway in West Bengal, and Nanik Amarnath Bhardwaj (popularly known as Lala Amarnath), the first Indian to score a 100 in a